

8 Tips for Getting the Most from All-You-Can-Eat Buffets

Food can serve many purposes. For some it is merely for nourishment. For others it is a form of art or a means of entertainment. For still others, it fills an emotional need and could even be considered an addiction or vice. For the purpose of this article, I'd like to point out that my advice is for the most basic of needs: good nutrition, a bit of indulgence, and a chance to fellowship with your family or friends with no dishes to clean up! Here are the eight ways we make our dining dollars a great investment.

1. Kids eat free (or almost free)

Yep, with four of them, it's important that we at least get a generous discount, if not a total write-off on the little darlings. In my area, Tuesday is usually the "Kids Eat Free Day" and requires that at least one adult purchase is made for every one (or

even two) free kids' meals. Be sure that if you are dining at a chain restaurant, you call ahead to see if they honor national promotions.

2. Lunch is served

If at all possible, eat the lunch buffet. There is usually at least a \$2–\$3 difference in the pricing of lunch and dinner, and usually the offerings are similar. In rare instances, an evening buffet may offer something special, like nicer steak, crab legs, or a themed dinner. Weigh your options to decide if this is worth it. I won't justify the extra for a cheap steak, but a couple of jumbo crab legs might seal the deal.

3. Skip the beverage (or plan accordingly)

Drinks can make an otherwise affordable buffet downright expensive. If drinks are included in the meal price, go for it. If not, you may want to stick to water with lemon, or decide on only one drink. (Some places will let you get a soft drink with your meal and a coffee afterward, but may charge you for two drinks.)

4. Fill up on fresh

I know that those hot wings are tasty, and I'm also digging the homemade